A street corner. A shop. She was always wearing a disguise—a big blond wig. Or big black sunglasses. And yet I'd always recognize her.

I'd step forward, whisper: *Mummy? Is it you?*

Before she could answer, before I could find out where she'd been, why she hadn't come back, I'd snap awake.

I'd look around the room, feeling the crushing disappointment.

Only a dream. Again.

But then I'd tell myself: *Maybe that means…today's the day?*

I was like those religious fanatics who believe the world will end on such and such a date. And when the date passes uneventfully, their faith remains undaunted.

I must've misread the signs. Or the calendar.

I suppose I knew the truth deep in my heart. The illusion of Mummy hiding, preparing to return, was never so real that it could blot out reality entirely. But it blotted it out enough that I was able to postpone the bulk of my grief. I still hadn't mourned, still hadn't cried, except that one time at her grave, still hadn't processed the bare facts. Part of my brain knew, but part of it was wholly insulated, and the division between those two parts kept the parliament of my consciousness divided, polarized, gridlocked. Just as I wanted it.

Sometimes I'd have a stern talk with myself. *Everyone else seems to believe that Mummy is dead, full stop, so maybe you should get on board.*

But then I'd think: I'll believe it when I have proof.

With solid proof, I thought, I could properly mourn and cry and move on.

32.

I DON'T REMEMBER how we got the stuff. One of my mates, I expect. Or maybe several. Whenever we found ourselves in possession, we'd commandeer a tiny upstairs bathroom, wherein we'd implement a surprisingly thoughtful, orderly assembly line. Smoker straddled the loo beside the window, second boy leaned against the basin, third and fourth boys sat in the empty bath, legs dangling over, waiting their turns. You'd take a hit or two, blow the smoke out of the window, then move on to the next station, in rotation, until the spliff was gone. Then we'd all head to one of our rooms and giggle ourselves sick over an episode or two of a